Why were Bohr, Heisenberg, and others so convinced that the quantum world couldn't be visualized? Why did they seem to think that things couldn't be real until they were observed? Why did they insist that the classical world obeyed fundamentally different rules from the quantum world? Why, in short, did they believe the strange assemblage of claims that came to be known as the Copenhagen interpretation?

Niels Bohr's force of personality is the most obvious answer. But the next question is why Bohr had these ideas—or even whether he did. Bohr's writing is so difficult and obscure that it is hard to say what Bohr's own positions were, which makes it even harder to divine the ideas that influenced Bohr. (Amazingly, Bohr's students and colleagues cited complementarity as a reason for this. According to his students, Bohr himself had said that "truth was complementary to clarity," and thus, they claimed, "Bohr was a very bad speaker, because he was too much concerned with truth"; similarly, "his sentences were long, involuted and opaque" because he "strove for precision.") But Bohr's obfuscatory writing hasn't thwarted attempts to trace the origins of his ideas: on the contrary, there's a cottage industry of theorizing about what was happening inside the head of one Niels Henrik David Bohr. Some have suggested that he was influenced primarily by Kant; others have pointed at his compatriot Søren Kierkegaard (buried just a few dozen yards away from Bohr in Copenhagen's Assistens Cemetery); still others have seen the influence of gnosticism in the contradictions of complementarity. Bohr's most loyal and vocal advocate, Léon Rosenfeld, saw a consistent strain of Marxism in Bohr's writing and thoughts—an opinion that surely had nothing whatsoever to do with the fact that Rosenfeld himself was an avowed Marxist. In short, the literature on Bohr is vast and inconclusive (though most seem to agree that Kant's writing really did have some influence on him).

Bohr's opaque writing and peculiar ability to inspire devotion in his students and colleagues aren't the whole explanation, though. Another part of the answer lies in the intellectual atmosphere of the period itself. For